

Speech Therapy

Speech and Language Therapy for adults

We help adults with communication and swallowing problems.

Contact us

0300 123 0785

kentchft.aslt@nhs.net

Please complete our [Adult Community Speech and Language Therapy Service referral form](#) or you can be referred by a GP or healthcare professional.

See a list of our clinic locations below. Please use the phone numbers above when needing to contact the service. The numbers for the locations are reception numbers and not for our service.

Who we are

We are speech and language therapists (SLTs) and SLT assistants who specialise in assessing and treating communication and swallowing disorders using one-to-one or group therapy, carer support and advice. Our clients can have a range of long-term conditions including Parkinson's disease, motor neurone disease, multiple sclerosis, stroke, dementia and Huntington's disease. Please contact us if you would like to discuss a referral to our service.

What we do

We work in community clinics, hospitals, private homes and nursing and residential homes to assess, diagnose and help patients manage a variety of communication and swallowing disorders.

We specialise in acquired neurological disorders, older adult mental health, voice, head and neck oncology, dysphagia (swallowing disorders) and stammering.

Who we help

We help adults with:

- Aphasia: Difficulty finding words and making sentences or understanding what people say
- Dysarthria: Slurred or unclear speech.
- Dysphagia: Trouble swallowing
- Voice problems – a change in how your voice sounds or your throat feels, e.g. hoarse voice.
- Stammering – speech characterised by repetitions.

These difficulties may be due to conditions such as Parkinson's disease, motor neurone disease, multiple sclerosis, stroke, dementia, Huntington's disease, muscle tension dysphonia.

We work in:

- clinics
- community hospitals
- patient's homes
- care homes.

Care home staff should follow the guidance in the Kent Manual for Mealtimes before referring to SLT for swallowing assessment. Many eating, drinking and swallowing issues can be safely and effectively managed by care home staff and do not require specialist SLT assessment. Please see the [Kent Manual for Mealtimes](#) for more information, training and resources.

Who we cannot help

We cannot usually help people when the problem is due to:

- oesophageal stage swallowing difficulties
- difficulty swallowing tablets
- hearing problems
- autism related communication issues
- Bell's Palsy
- developmental communication difficulties (problems since childhood)
- people with a learning disability - contact the [Adult Learning Disability Team](#) on 0300 123 4195 or kentchft.ldsref@nhs.net
- selective mutism.

How do you use this service?

You can refer yourself, ask a doctor or anyone else involved in your care to refer you.

Please complete our [Adult Community Speech and Language Therapy Service referral form](#) to refer yourself.

Your referral will be triaged by a therapist and we will let you know if it has been accepted and added to our waiting list.

Waiting times

Waiting times can vary depending on the type of problem. We aim to see everyone within 12 weeks, although this may take longer.

What to do while you wait

- Have a look at our leaflets (see below)
- If you are waiting for help with swallowing, fill in a [swallowing diary](#)
- If your swallowing problem gets worse let us know
- If you are waiting for help with your voice you can look at the [Advice for a healthy voice leaflet](#) or the [British Voice Association website](#)
- If you no longer need help, please tell us.

What happens at your appointment?

- Communication: We will ask about your speaking or understanding and then agree a plan for the next step, which may be advice, more assessment or to be put on the waiting list for therapy. We can give you information about other services that could help. Sessions generally last about 45 minutes. You are welcome to bring somebody with you.
- Stammering: We will arrange an initial appointment which will last around 45 to 60 minutes. During this we will ask you about your stammer and the things that affect it. We will identify your reasons for wanting speech therapy and will discuss next steps, which will likely include further assessment and therapy. You will also be directed to other helpful resources.
- Swallowing: we will ask about your swallowing difficulties. This will take generally around 45 to 60 minutes. We will give you recommendations around eating and drinking and explain why you might be having swallowing difficulties. We might ask your doctor to refer you for further tests.
- Voice: We will take a case history including questions about your voice change and will listen to your voice to complete a perceptual assessment. We may record your voice using expert equipment for further analysis. If required we will book you in for a course of therapy.

